towards me would lead me to finally focus on minute details. It could have been one reason that my check sortie went well with the CFI, who seemed quite impressed after the sortie was over. In fact, he was so impressed that he asked my instructor, ‘Babs Sir’ as we called him, to prepare me for a solo sortie after my tenth sortie, where I would have to fly the aircraft from take-off to landing all on my own. Generally, it was the fourteenth sortie where a solo check would be carried out. To go solo after just the tenth sortie would be quite early for me and I could get worked up, Babs Sir knew this well. So he kept this news from me. It was during the debriefing of my ninth sortie that Babs Sir broke the news to me that I would be going solo the next day, right after my tenth sortie.

‘But how is this possible, Sir?’ I started to whine. ‘I’m not even prepared for it. It should be done after my fourteenth. Why now?’

‘Don’t get nervous, Gunjan, just fly a normal sortie. Fly how you fly with me. If you won’t perform well, he won’t clear you. It’ll be recorded as a normal training sortie then,’ Babs Sir tried to reassure me. He and I both knew that if it didn’t go well, there were chances the CFI would put it in my folder as a failed check sortie. If a cadet didn’t clear a check sortie and it got recorded in his or her folder, he or she might have to go through a termination review board and be thrown out of the flying branch eventually.

‘Don’t worry, nothing bad will happen,’ Babs Sir said, and asked me to go and get a good night’s sleep. Anuradha tried to cheer me up as we pedalled our bicycles towards our squadron. I should focus on the bright side of it, she said. But I was too nervous to even listen to her. After the open-door study period and a quick dinner, I came back to my cabin to prepare the lights-out report. To my astonishment, WUO Preeti Lavale called me to her cabin at nine instead of ten. When she began my ragda session, even after I had requested her to excuse me for the night, it added to my frustration. A rigorous half-hour of punishment followed. When I finally reached my cabin by half past nine, I was too exhausted to worry about the next day. No sooner did I hit the bed than I fell into a dreamless slumber. Anuradha would tell me later that the WUO had intentionally